

Research Title: The Relationship between Parental Overprotection, Self-Efficacy, and Autonomy among Emerging Adults in Bangladesh.

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Abstract

Parental involvement remains an important source of support during emerging adulthood, yet excessive protection and intervention can restrict opportunities for independent action and decision-making. This study examined the relationships among perceived parental overprotection, self-efficacy and autonomy among emerging adults in Bangladesh. A sequential explanatory mixed-methods design was employed, beginning with a quantitative survey of 87 participants followed by qualitative interviews with 13 survey respondents. The three quantitative measures demonstrated high internal consistency. Pearson's correlation analysis showed that parental overprotection was strongly and negatively associated with self-efficacy ($r = -.703$, $p < .001$) and weaker but significantly associated with autonomy ($r = -.242$, $p = .024$). Self-efficacy was positively associated with autonomy ($r = .590$, $p < .001$). Regression analysis indicated that parental overprotection accounted for approximately 49% of the variance in self-efficacy and 6% of the variance in autonomy. Qualitative findings contextualised these relationships by identifying parental monitoring, influence over major decisions, fear of mistakes, communication, trust and gradual responsibility as important features of participants' experiences. The findings suggest that the developmental significance of parental involvement depends on whether it supports or substitutes for emerging adults' opportunities to develop competence, responsibility and meaningful autonomy.

Keywords: parental overprotection, self-efficacy, autonomy, emerging adulthood, parenting, Bangladesh

1. Introduction

Parental protection involves developmentally appropriate care and guidance that safeguards children while still allowing increasing independence and autonomy. In contrast, parental overprotection involves excessive restriction, monitoring, or intervention that limits age-appropriate autonomy and opportunities to develop independent competence [1]. More